BALTIC CONFLICTS



Battle of Fredrikshamn
On May 15, 1790, the Swedish fleet under the command of King Gustavus III engaged and destroyed a Russian fleet off Fredrikshamn (now Hamina, Finland) in the Gulf of Finland.

Running the gauntlet
After two disastrous attacks on the Russian fleet, the 400-strong Swedish fleet found itself blockaded in Vyborg Bay on July 3, 1790, by 150 Russian ships. Thanks to a lucky change in wind direction, they were able to escape, but lost 10 ships.

THE BALTIC WAS A STRATEGICALLY crucial area of Europe in the Age of Sail, for it was a source of vital nautical supplies—timber, tar, flax, and hemp—as well as of other important trade goods. Yet the naval conflicts in the region fought in the 17th and 18th centuries were almost exclusively contests between the countries around the Baltic shores. The Dutch intervened in Baltic warfare to protect their naval supplies and trading interests in the 17th century, as the British later did during the Napoleonic Wars, but mostly the combatants were Sweden, the kingdom of Denmark-Norway and, in the 18th century, Russia. The battles they fought often took place in the shallow waters around the inlets and islands of the Baltic coast. Thus in Baltic navies large sailing ships were often less decisive in combat than shallow-draft oared galleys and flat-bottomed boats.

POWERFUL SWEDES

Sweden established its independence from Denmark and Norway in the 1520s. A navy was founded under King Gustav Vasa (ruled 1523–60), but when his famous grandson Gustavus Adolphus came to the throne in 1611 it consisted only of small and aging vessels.

To serve both his military ambitions and sense of personal prestige, in the 1620s the king had a new fleet built at the Royal Dockyard in Stockholm, under the direction of Dutch master shipwright Henriks Hybertszoon. This included some of the largest warships in the world, but was far from a total success. The mighty *Vasa*, intended to be the pride of the new navy, sank ignominiously in Stockholm Harbor on her maiden voyage in August 1628. This was not untypical of the general performance of the Swedish navy.

The Danes benefited from the income generated by the tolls on the straits they controlled at the mouth of the Baltic. They were also aided by the formidable